

Emergency School Committee Meeting

Thursday, March 12, 2020

Council Chambers, Medford City Hall

Present: Mr. Ruseau, Ms. Van der Kloot, Ms. Kreatz, Ms. McLaughlin, Ms. Mustone, Mayor Lungo-Koehn, Superintendent Dr. Edouard-Vincent, Associate Superintendent Ms. Caldwell, Assistant Superintendent Dr. Cushing, and Assistant Superintendent of Finance Ms. Patterson. Ms. Graham participated remotely.

Roll Call and Salute the Flag - Meeting called to order at 4:10 pm

Mayor - Earlier today, I attended the Metro Mayors Association Meeting regarding the Coronavirus outbreak. The main topic of discussion was how to keep our residents, employees, staff, and students safe. We were informed to restrict gatherings to 25 people or less, including all public meetings. We all were told to keep a social distance or at least 6 feet away from others.

To that end, we will be closing the following public entities beginning tomorrow and continuing until April 15, 2020. We will re-evaluate at that time.

Medford Senior Center and Medford Recreation - Closed, all programming cancelled. Refunds will be given.

Medford City Hall - will remain open, but I am encouraging that citizens only enter who require emergency assistance. Employees will hold conference calls and on-line meetings.

According to the state Department of Public Health - Massachusetts cases of Coronavirus keep rising. Therefore if you are sick, please stay home. Please wash your hands frequently. If you think you might have the Coronavirus, please call your primary doctor first! Do not go to your primary doctor's office or to the emergency room. However, if you are having trouble breathing, then you should go to an emergency room.

At this time, I am urging our citizens to not panic. To please be kind and compassionate to your neighbors. My priority is to keep our community healthy and safe. We are Medford Strong!

We meet today, at an unprecedented time, and after much discussion with our Superintendent and other school leaders, we have made the decision to close all of the Medford Public Schools, effective immediately, for (2) weeks. Our first and foremost goal must be the health and safety of all of students, teachers, administrators, and staff.

The City's Food Security Task Force - has been mobilized to provide food and other supports for those who may need it. At this point, working together with the Malden Y, they intend to offer grab and go options, from Monday-Friday, at the McGlynn School, the Medford Youth Center (30 Forest St), the Willis Avenue Social Center, the Unitarian Church FoodPantry, and the new Mystic Food Market, on Mystic Avenue. Syrah McGivern of the Board of Health is gathering a list of volunteers.

As a City we needed to act quickly and proactively to combat this virus. We intend to provide frequent updates on both the City of Medford and the Medford Public Schools websites, and will do so as frequently as we can.

Ms Van der Kloot - Thank you Mayor Lungo-Koehn. This is the right choice at this time. With everything I have read today, I feel this is the decisive choice. However this will be difficult for many families with child care. But the right thing going forward. How will students be notified? Via Capt Clemente?

Superintendent - We will send out emails and a robo call to all students, as well as,send an email to all staff. In addition, we will notify all the television stations as well.

Ms. McLaughlin - Thank you for your commitment to our city and community. I realize this an ongoing process, but will there be somewhere questions can be directed? Can we have a gmail account set up? What about our vulnerable populations and those who receive therapeutic services? What should families expect?

Ms. Bowen - We have already been working with our special education team and our highest priority is to provide services, whether through phone calls, zoom or SKYPE. We are thinking outside the box. For families with questions, they can email me directly.

Ms. Kreatz - Thank you for calling this emergency meeting. I know the Governor urged that schools close. I think he suggested revisiting the time frame later. Will we be able to provide any type of child care?

Mayor - I realize that a lot of elderly parents provide child care and at this time, that certainly is not the best option . Children can be carriers and have no symptoms . Our main concern has to be to slow down the spread of the virus. It will affect the economy. We do not have any child care options to offer right now. We will not have all questions answered today

Mr. Ruseau - the television feed is down, so can we take a break?

Mayor - The feed is is running live, just a lot of people jumping onto the feed

Ms. Kreatz - Will the schools be open tomorrow for any pick up for students/staff?

Mayor - Yes, Dr. Cushing will be sending out a robo call indicating the time frame for that.

Mr. Ruseau - Is there a date that the community will know if dates will be extended? So people can try to plan?

Mayor - We are planning on a 2 weeks minimum, and we will let people know as soon as possible. But discussions have mentioned between 2-8 weeks

Mr. Ruseau - How can we provide education for students while not in school? What are the expectations?

Superintendent - We have been collaborating to provide assignments for our students. We will provide this information online.

Ms. Mustone - Are all Mayors planning a 2 week shutdown?

Mayor - Most Mayors are doing the 2 weeks.

Ms. McLaughlin - There are no positive cases in the Medford Public Schools?

Superintendent - No

Ms. Kreatz - Will payroll be open? Will the scheduled subcommittee meetings be held?

Superintendent - At this point in time, we must pay people. As always, our priority is to keep students and our community.

Mayor - We can film subcommittees and people can email questions

Ms. Van der Kloot - What about the school administration? The custodians?

Superintendent - Administration will stay working remotely.

Mayor - We plan to figure out who are non essential personnel - we aren't there yet, but we plan to get there

Mr. Ruseau - We must pay attention to hourly staff! We have to remember them financially

Mayor -Currently, we are operating in a crisis situation. Please keep separate spreadsheets of the expenses incurred during it.

Ms. Van der Kloot - What about the students who have medication in the nurses offices in our schools? Do we need to return it to them?

Mayor - That information will be included in the schools robocall

Ms. McLaughlin - Citizens have come to this meeting. Do you have any questions?

Mayor - Sure. We will do our best to answer them

Paul - 29 Rural Avenue - Are buses being disinfected ?

Superintendent - Buses are being deep cleaned, once a week

Amanda O'Leary - How can we assist with food security?

Mayor - smcgivern@medford-ma.gov

Ms. Kreatz - Will students have to remain in school past June? What about MCAS?

Superintendent - We will rely on DESE to answer those questions

Mr. Ruseau - I feel communication is always a challenge. I make a motion, if it would be possible for us to receive updates, every other day? Seconded by Ms. McLaughlin. Motion passes

Motion to adjourn by Ms. McLaughlin, seconded by Ms. Van der Kloot. Motion passes

Meeting was adjourned at - 4:45 PM